

burg's two grounds at 5,557 ft above sea level. It is perilously close to the mark where doctors believe altitude sickness begins to set in.

The big Bafana already know. After being knocked out of the group stages of the Confederation Cup in South Africa last year, Italy went up to 6,677 ft at Sestriere and ran laps with monitors strapped to their chests to check heart rates. Mexico spent a month in the German Alps. Brazil stayed home in Curitiba which just climbs over 3,000 ft.

As if the football World Cup did not have its own rare air.

Already, Spain are gasping. The Furia Roja (Red Fury) are now marked down as favourites. Ahead of Brazil, imagine that. Almost by custom, the Brazilians are supposed to be the leading Cup contenders and are even back at the top of the FIFA rankings. But still, the people, not just the punters, say Spain can win the Cup it never has. The

team has had only 10 days to train in Austria with their leading players packed into the last stages of European club competitions. South Africa's impending winter be damned, Spain is not enjoying the heat at all.

"We would like not to have this role of favourites but we have it and have to accept it," says striker Fernando Torres, just off knee surgery, one of four players worn out by a long season and nagging injuries. Coach Vicente del Bosque is sighing deeply, hoping that his countrymen are listening. "Everybody in Spain thinks that anything except winning the World Cup is a failure," he says. Normally this could have turned off the gloomy but there is

an infectious belief in Spain's golden generation squad and its Midas-class men of skill.

Maybe the world wants Spain to be the old Brazil because the new one has invested in none of the silken samba that made it the Cup's perpetual paramours. Brazil captain Lucio is stern, "To those who complain about style, I just say nothing is more beautiful than winning—that's the spectacle we should be giving to people."

England is still longing for the spectacle, all hearts fluttering faster again. A nation cannot decide whether the World Cup is time to invest in a football bond which offers a 0.5 per cent bonus if England wins or to just

376 channels across 214 countries and territories will broadcast the 2010 World Cup to an estimated 715 million viewers.

buy "stab vests" and travel to football country, knife-wielding citizens and all.

This whirlpool of worry lies in the muscle memory of the Cup, an anachronism against the machine that is club football. Two hundred years ago, Europe went in all directions looking for territory and riches and no borders mattered. Today the world's best players now gravitate towards the fertile and porous professional leagues of England, Spain and Italy. Owners of behemoth clubs tap into decades-old loyalties and set in motion a commercial enterprise that seeks, buys and swaps talent. It is how soccer's galaxy now swirls non-stop.

Every four years though, the World Cup suddenly arrives to shake the ground beneath football's feet. It is the unknown craftsman's ticket from unfashionable livelihood to professional El Dorado. To the giants of Europe, the Cup is the sight of their sport in life-size with its arms stretched around the planet.

The diamond-studded Cristiano Ronaldo, the world's highest-paid footballer and Real Madrid's centrifugal force, admitted to feeling



Patrice Evra
Wing Back,
France

Cristiano Ronaldo
Striker,
Portugal

Wesley Sneijder
Midfielder,
Netherlands